EVERY DAY, A NEW PROTEST



Editorial illustration: protest movements in India, France and the United States. This is an illustration, not a documentary photograph of one event.

The world seems to wake up to a new protest every day. Students march over exams, women demand safety and dignity, citizens question elections, and workers protest the rising cost of living. From the streets of India to a historic town hall in France and demonstrations in the United States, the scenes are different—but the question is familiar: what happens when people feel they are not being heard?

1. India: Students, women and the question of trust

In India, protests often begin with a demand for fairness. For students, competitive examinations such as NEET can represent years of preparation, family sacrifice and the hope of a future career. Allegations of paper leaks or irregularities can turn that hope into anger. Young people who believe their future has been put at risk take to the streets asking for transparent investigations and accountability.

Women's groups have also marched against violence, discrimination and alleged mistreatment during demonstrations. Their message is not simply that they want to be safe in public spaces; it is that institutions must listen when women report harm. Meanwhile, the phrase "vote chori"—literally, "vote theft"—has become a political rallying cry around allegations concerning electoral rolls and the fairness of elections. These are contested claims, not proof of wrongdoing by themselves, and they require evidence, transparent procedures and independent scrutiny.

Recent reporting in October 2026 described protests over electoral-roll revisions and calls for accountability, alongside international concern about alleged excessive force against demonstrators. The Election Commission and government institutions have their own explanations and procedures; a fair account must examine both the allegations and the evidence. The larger issue is trust: people need to believe that exams are fair, complaints are investigated and votes are counted through a credible process.

2. France: A historic building consumed by fire

On 17 October 2026, protests across France over the cost of living and conditions in schools were accompanied by clashes and acts of destruction. In Limoges, a fire devastated the city's historic town hall, inaugurated in 1883. Reports said the roof and tower were badly damaged or collapsed. The building had stood through two world wars, yet it was severely damaged in a single night of unrest.

The image is powerful because a public building is more than stone, timber and a clock tower: it carries a city's memories. But it is important not to confuse a protest movement with every act committed during it. Many people may demonstrate peacefully while a smaller group engages in arson or looting. Burning a civic building does not automatically make a protest's original grievances disappear, but it can endanger lives, destroy shared heritage and shift public attention away from the issues that brought people into the streets.

France's experience leaves a difficult question: how can a society protect the right to protest while also protecting people, public spaces and historic places from violence?

3. Donald Trump: Protests, force and "law and order"

In the United States, President Donald Trump's response to protests has often emphasised law and order. During demonstrations in Los Angeles in June 2025 linked to federal immigration enforcement, Trump defended the deployment of National Guard troops and Marines and warned that further protests could face equal or greater force. His public comments presented the response as a way to protect police and restore order.

Supporters of a hard-line response argue that authorities must prevent violence and protect people and property. Critics warn that deploying military forces against demonstrations can escalate tensions and chill peaceful dissent. These positions raise a basic democratic distinction: authorities can act against specific violence, but peaceful assembly and criticism of government are also fundamental rights. A protest should not be treated as violent simply because it is inconvenient or politically uncomfortable.

When the shouting fades

Across countries, protests are not all the same. Some demand exam justice, some challenge alleged electoral wrongdoing, some oppose economic hardship, and others resist government policy. Some remain peaceful; others are overtaken by violence. Each event deserves careful reporting rather than a single label.

A protest is a warning signal: something in the relationship between people and power may need attention. Governments have a duty to maintain public safety, and protesters have a responsibility not to harm others. Journalists have another duty—to verify claims, distinguish peaceful demonstrators from those who commit violence, and ask who is being heard and who is being ignored.

Perhaps the most important question is not why the world protests every day, but why so many people feel they must. The answer begins when we look beyond the smoke, slogans and headlines—and listen to the demands beneath them.

Reporting notes / sources for verification

•Reuters,“Modi’spredicament:GenZpoursoutonIndia’sstreetsasdissentsurges,” 16 October 2026: https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/modis-predicament-gen-z-pours-out-indias-streets-dissent-surges-2026-10-16/

• Reuters, “In France’s Limoges, the fire-ravaged town hall rekindles memories of Notre Dame,” 18 October 2026: https://www.reuters.com/world/frances-limoges-fire-ravaged-town-hall-rekindles-memories-notre-dame-2026-10-18/

• Euronews, “Spire collapses at historic Limoges town hall amid violent protests across France,” 18 October 2026: https://www.euronews.com/2026/10/18/spire-collapses-at-historic-limoges-town-hall-amid-violent-protests-across-france

• The White House / U.S. Government Publishing Office, Trump remarks on political protests in Los Angeles, 8 June 2025: https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/DCPD-202500673/html/DCPD-202500673.htm

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